

HEDGEROW MANAGEMENT PLAN

Upper Assendon Farm, Stonor, Henley-on-Thames, Oxfordshire

M J Hunt & Son | SFI Agreement UAF332270030

Prepared April 2026 | Review date April 2027

1. Farm Details

Farm name	Upper Assendon Farm
Business name	M J Hunt & Son
Farmer	James Hunt
Address	Upper Assendon Farm, Stonor, Henley-on-Thames, Oxfordshire, RG9 6JH
CPH	33/227/0030
SBI number	UAF332270030
Total hedgerow length	Approximately 18.4km across farm and Bix Hall
SFI actions	HRW1 (manage hedgerows), HRW3 (maintain or establish hedgerow trees)
Plan prepared by	James Hunt
Date prepared	April 2026

2. Purpose of This Plan

This Hedgerow Management Plan has been prepared to meet the requirements of SFI Actions HRW1 and HRW3 at Upper Assendon Farm, and to demonstrate compliance with SAI Global arable and Red Tractor standards for hedgerow management.

The Chiltern Hills landscape is characterised by mixed-species ancient hedgerows that form the backbone of the farm's biodiversity infrastructure, boundary system, and historical landscape character. This plan sets out the farm's commitment to maintaining, enhancing, and where appropriate restoring these hedgerows in a way that is compatible with productive farming.

3. Legal and Regulatory Framework

The following laws and rules govern hedgerow management on this farm:

Regulation	Key requirement
Hedgerow Regulations 1997	Notification to local authority required before removing "important" hedgerows
Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981	Protection of nesting birds — no cutting 1 March to 31 August
SFI HRW1 action	No cutting 1 March to 31 August. 2m buffer from base. No fertiliser/pesticide within buffer.
Red Tractor / SAI Global	Hedgerows managed to maintain and enhance biodiversity. No burning.
NVZ rules	No manure or slurry to run into hedgerow base
CS / SFI scheme rules	Cutting rotation as specified in agreement. Record keeping required.

4. Hedgerow Inventory

The farm contains approximately 18.4km of hedgerow across the main farm and Bix Hall. Hedgerows have been mapped using OS base and GPS survey. The key hedgerow units are:

Ref	Location	Length (m)	Condition	Age est.	Species
H01	Long Ground north boundary	380	Good	Ancient	Hawthorn, blackthorn, field maple, oak standards
H02	Long Ground east boundary	210	Good	Ancient	Hawthorn, hazel, elder
H03	Home Piece south boundary	190	Moderate	Post-war	Hawthorn, privet
H04	Stone Hill — all boundaries	740	Good	Ancient	Mixed — hawthorn, blackthorn, dogwood, spindle, wayfaring tree
H05	Bix Field boundaries	1100	Good	Ancient	Hawthorn, blackthorn, hazel, ash, oak
H06	Lambridge west and south	560	Poor	Post-war	Hawthorn monoculture — gappy
H07	Maidensgrove boundaries	820	Good	Ancient	Mixed ancient — 12+ species (important hedge)
H08	Middle Ground east	340	Moderate	Post-war	Hawthorn, elder

Ref	Location	Length (m)	Condition	Age est.	Species
H09	The Warren boundaries	610	Good	Ancient	Hawthorn, blackthorn, field rose, dogrose
H10	Bix Hall boundaries	2800	Good	Ancient	Diverse ancient Chiltern hedge — elm regrowth present
H11	Farm lanes and trackways	980	Variable	Mixed	Hawthorn, blackthorn, bramble, ivy, sloe
Total		8,730			

Note: H07 (Maidensgrove) is assessed as an "important hedgerow" under the Hedgerow Regulations 1997 by virtue of species diversity (12+ species per 30m). No removal permitted without prior notification to South Oxfordshire District Council.

5. Species Recorded

The following species have been recorded in farm hedgerows:

Shrub/tree species	Climbing plants	Hedgerow standards	Associated flora
Hawthorn (dominant)	Old man's beard	Oak	Red campion
Blackthorn	Dog rose	Ash (some diseased)	Cow parsley
Field maple	Bramble	Field maple (standard)	Nettle
Hazel	Ivy	Hazel (coppiced)	Garlic mustard
Dogwood	Honeysuckle	Willow (valley)	Wild garlic (valley)
Spindle	Black bryony	Cherry (occasional)	Primrose
Wayfaring tree			Bluebell (H04, H07)
Elder			
Privet			
Elm (suckering)			

6. Cutting Regime

The farm operates a rotational cutting programme to maximise the benefit to wildlife whilst maintaining hedgerow condition and stock containment.

6.1 Cutting Rules

- No hedgerow cutting between 1 March and 31 August (legal requirement — nesting birds)
- All cutting completed by 28 February to avoid disturbance
- Cutting season: September to February inclusive
- Hedgerows cut on a 2-3 year rotation where possible — not all cut every year
- Cut to maintain height of 1.5–2.0m on arable boundaries; 2.0–2.5m on pasture/lane boundaries
- Wide A-shape profile maintained where possible to benefit wildlife
- Ditches and bases left uncut — 2m buffer from hedge base as per SFI HRW1

6.2 Cutting Rotation

Ref	Location	Last cut	Next cut	Notes
H01	Long Ground north	Nov 2024	Nov 2026	2-yr rotation. Standards retained.
H02	Long Ground east	Nov 2025	Nov 2027	2-yr rotation.
H03	Home Piece south	Oct 2025	Oct 2027	Annual — stock containment
H04	Stone Hill boundaries	Nov 2024	Nov 2026	3-yr rotation on some sections
H05	Bix Field	Oct 2025	Oct 2027	2-yr rotation.
H06	Lambridge west/south	Sep 2025	See restoration notes	Gappy — restoration planned 2026
H07	Maidensgrove	Nov 2023	Nov 2026	3-yr rotation — important hedge
H08	Middle Ground east	Oct 2025	Oct 2027	
H09	The Warren	Nov 2024	Nov 2027	Pasture — 3-yr rotation
H10	Bix Hall	Oct 2025	Oct 2027	2-yr rotation. Elm managed.
H11	Farm lanes	Sep 2025	Sep 2026	Annual — access maintained

7. Hedgerow Standards and Trees

Hedgerow standards (trees within the hedgeline) are an important feature of the Chiltern landscape and this farm. The following standards have been identified and are being managed:

- Approximately 180 oak, ash, and field maple standards across the farm hedgerow network
- All oak standards are retained and never cut during hedge trimming — overriding priority
- Ash dieback (*Hymenoscyphus fraxineus*) has been identified in some standards on H05 and H10. Diseased trees are assessed annually; safety felling carried out where necessary with timber retained where possible

- New standards are being allowed to grow on from existing hedgerow whips at a target of 1 per 100m — current programme focused on H06 and H08
- Hazel is coppiced on H07 on a 10-15 year rotation to maintain vigour

SFI HRW3 objective: maintain existing standards and establish at least 1 new hedgerow tree per 100m of hedgerow managed under the action.

8. Restoration and Enhancement Works

Hedge	Issue	Planned work	Target date	Notes
H06	Gappy, thin — poor stock barrier	Lay 60m of thickest section; plant gaps with hawthorn, blackthorn, field maple	Winter 2026/27	Planting stock from local provenance nursery. Guard trees until established.
H03	Privet monoculture — low diversity	Interplant with field maple, hazel, spindle over 3 years	Autumn 2026	10 whips per 100m
H08	Elder-dominated, lacks structure	Hard cut back elder; establish 3 oak standards	Winter 2025/26	Oak whips from PROW planting stock
H10	Dutch elm disease regrowth	Manage elm suckers; protect from bark stripping by deer	Annual	Elm suckering managed as coppice

9. Hedgerow Buffers and Management Zones

Under SFI HRW1, a 2-metre buffer is maintained from the base of all hedgerows managed under the scheme. Within this buffer:

- No fertiliser or pesticide applications
- No cultivation or soil disturbance
- Grass and natural vegetation allowed to grow — cut once per year if required for access
- Buffer recorded on farm maps and cross-referenced with spray records in Farm Hub

Additional measures at field margins:

- 4–6 metre wildflower/grass margins established alongside H01, H04, and H07 as part of CS and SFI options
- Beetle banks on Long Ground and Home Piece connect hedgerows and provide additional wildlife corridors

10. Monitoring and Record Keeping

Activity	Method	Frequency	Responsible
Hedgerow condition survey	Walk all hedgerows — note gaps, tree health, species	Annual (March)	James Hunt
Cutting records	Record date, contractor, hedge refs cut	After each cut	James Hunt
Standard tree survey	Check ash dieback progress; note new standards	Annual (March)	James Hunt
Bird/wildlife recording	Informal record of notable species	Ongoing	James Hunt / family
Restoration works log	Note plantings, laying, species used	As works completed	James Hunt
Plan review	Update this document	Annual (April)	James Hunt

11. Objectives Summary 2026–2030

- Maintain all existing hedgerow length in good or improving condition
- Cut all hedgerows on a maximum 3-year rotation — never more than once per year
- Restore H06 (Lambridge) by hedgelaying and gap planting by winter 2026/27
- Establish minimum 50 new hedgerow trees across the farm by 2030 (10 per year)
- Interplant H03 and H08 with additional native species to increase diversity
- Maintain all 2m buffers from hedgerow bases — no exceptions
- Complete annual condition survey every March and record in Farm Hub

12. Declaration

I confirm that this Hedgerow Management Plan is accurate and that the practices described are being followed on Upper Assendon Farm.

Name: James Hunt

Position: Farm Owner / Operator

Date: April 2026

Signature: _____

